Broken – A Collection in Memory of Matthew Shepard

By Leslea Newman, Rachel Hadas, Beatrix Gates and Patricia Spears Jones

What You Can Do in 18 Hours by Leslea Newman

(Pg 17) Write a term paper
Cram for a final

Fly across the ocean
Drive cross-country

Scale a mountain
Run a marathon

See the moon disappear
Watch the sun rise and set

Wait to be discovered
lashed to a fence

Shivering under a blanket
of stars

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INTRODUCTION

On October 6, 1998, Aaron McKinney and Russel Henderson savagely beat Matthew Shepard, lashed him to a fence, and left him to die for no reason other than his sexual preference. And the nation was shocked . . . But it was obviously an isolated incident, or so it was claimed.

Now more than 20 years later, our society has become jaded to violence and suffering. Another school shooting? More immigrants denied asylum? Another unarmed black, or Asian or homosexual murdered? Thoughts and prayers (beat) and we move on.

*But these are **not** isolated incidents . . . they happen because our society is . . . Broken – A Collection in Memory of Matthew Shepard by Leslea Newman, Rachel Hadas, Beatrix Gates and Patricia Spears Jones*

The Fence by Rachel Hadas

(Pg 52) How does justice work?

Punishment? Revenge?

Is one life worth

more than another?

No one to see

whose tears washed two paths

clean on his bloody face,

who stood, wrists bound

(the ropes, a sheriff said,

almost too tight to cut),

tied to a fence under the autumn sky

as night turned into day.

No one nearby.

No one to say

whose enemy he was,

whose prey, and why.

Seeking Tenderness by Beatrix Gates

(Pg 35) [But] Stories walk backwards

out of the split-rail lodgepole pine,

the deer fence where you hung . . .

TRANSITION

And if we trace the story back . . . Aaron McKinney and Russell Henderson were products of the society that raised them. The boys who hung Matthew's broken body (crucified not with nails but with rope) to a fence, were sentenced to life behind bars. And society brushed off its culpability, sighed and moved on . . .

(Pg 36) Someone said that Aaron, like a lot of people who

talk a lot,

had nothing to say, that his friends called him a shrimp,

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just bullied him around,

"He wasn't the mean guy,"

one said, "he was just Aaron, the little guy."

Once Upon a Time by Leslea Newman

(Pg 81) *(in Aaron's voice)* "I don't like gay people. As far as Matt is concerned, I don't have any remorse"

Seeking Tenderness by Beatrix Gates

(Pg 37) *(in the landlady's voice)*

"Russell's about the most American

kid you can get. He's a pizza-eating, beer-drinking,

fishing, hunting, work-on-your-car

type of kid – just regular," his landlady said.

Wounded by Leslea Newman

(Pg 78) *(In Russell's voice)* "You know, my mom was killed in Laramie. She was raped, and then the guy just left her on the side of the road."

TRANSITION

Matthew was taken to Poudre Valley Hospital in Fort Collins, Colorado, where he died six days later. And that Saturday afternoon, a few blocks from his hospital bed, it was a celebration: The Colorado State University homecoming parade. Spirits were high and the floats were spectacular. Well, except for the Wizard of Oz float . . . Our society is broken.

The Frat Boys by Leslea Newman

(Pg 51) Hey, wouldn't it be funny

Hey, wouldn't it be hysterial

Hey, wouldn't it be a riot

to make our scarecrow

the scarecrow on our float

the scarecrow on our homecoming float

look like a homo

look like a queer

look like a freakin' fairy?

Hey, that would be funny

Hey, that would be hysterical

Hey, that would be a riot

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Like that fag from Wyoming

that fag they tied to the fence

that fag they thought was a scarecrow

Seeking Tenderness by Beatrix Gates

(Pg 39) The cyclist who found Matthew Shepard

thought he was a scarecrow

until he saw the human hair.

The Frat Boys by Leslea Newman

(Pg 51) Let's write I LIKE BOYS on his shirt

Let's write I'M GAY on his hat

Let's write I LOVE DICK on his pants

Hey, that's really funny

Hey, that's really hysterical

Hey, that's really a riot . . .

Hey, that'll knock 'em dead

My Matthew Shepard Poem by Patricia Spears Jones

(Pg 65-66) What I know about America is that hatred
crawls through the culture like the cracks
in the San Andreas fault.

Edifices are built to withstand the inevitable
quakes, but the quakes grow stronger.
Whatever we dream -- harmony or a reasonable tolerance -
-- is destroyed in the wake

of men drinking and killing. Their blood lusted
laughter howling through the night.

A Black man in Texas. A white man in Wyoming.
A doctor at his window about to eat dinner with his family.
A nurse on her way to work at a clinic.

The playing field is not level. In fact, there is no playing
field.
There are men enraged by change. And women bitter
about it.
And people, say

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gay, Black, Latino, Chinese, Japanese, Arab, or Jewish
to blame, always to blame.

The ugly men in their same wool suits and striped ties
gibber political correctness, freedom, fairness
every time they claim that these are acts of individuals, not
of society.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Leslea Newman
Book: October Mourning: A Song for Matthew Shepard
ISBN: 978-0763658076
Publisher: Candlewick
Date (Month/Year): Sept 2012
Poems:

- ***What You Can Do in Eighteen Hours***
- ***Once Upon a Time***
- ***Wounded***
- ***Frat Boys***

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Scott Gibson (Editor)
Book: Blood & Tears: Commemorative Poems for Matthew Shepard
ISBN: 978-1891305153
Publisher: Painted Leaf Press
Date (Month/Year): June 1999
Poems:

- ***The Fence by Rachel Hadas***
- ***Seeking Tenderness by Beatrix Gates***
- ***My Matthew Shepard Poem by Patricia Spears Jones***

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**According to "The Crucifixion of Matthew Shepard" by Melanie Thernstrom, published in Vanity Fair, March 1999. "On Saturday afternoon, a few blocks from the hospital bed where Matthew's parents were keeping vigil, a Colorado State University homecoming parade passed by. ON a Wizard of Oz float sponsored by the Pi Kappa Alpha fraternity and Alpha Chi Omega sorority, the scarecrow character had been defaced. Scrawled in black spray paint was I'M GAY, as well as anti-homosexual obscenities."*

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